

bite of SALVATION

✱ **N. Krishnan, 27**

Project To feed the old, mentally ill and homeless in Madurai

Can-do Icon Mother Teresa, who inspires him to carry on with his good work

310 million

Indians live below the poverty line. The poverty rate of the country is 28 per cent.

Six years ago, a catering technology graduate from Kamaraj University decided to quit his job at a five-star hotel in Bangalore to serve food to the hungry, old,

disabled and mentally ill, who wander in the streets of Madurai. All it took to change

N. Krishnan, then just another ambitious, young hotelier on his way to Switzerland,

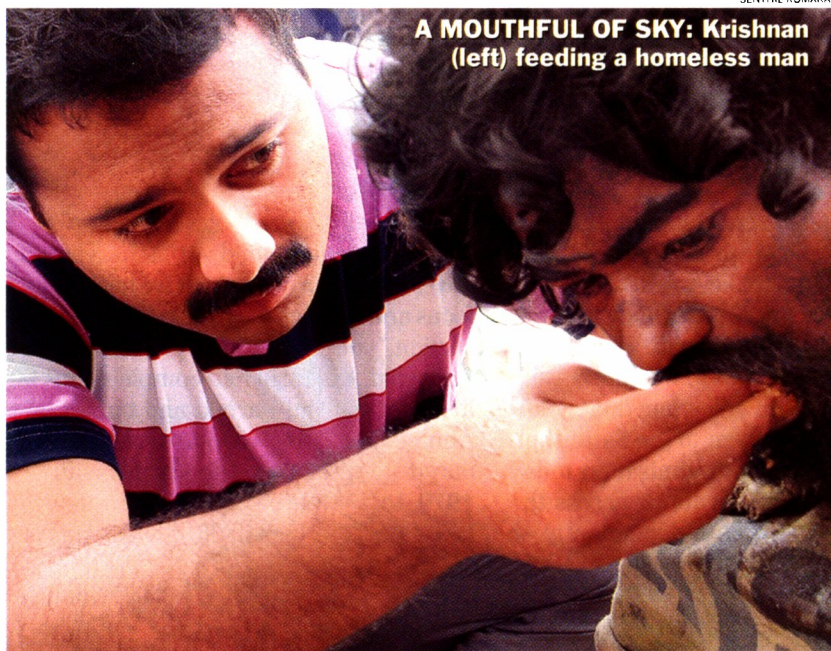
was a visit to his hometown. One day, he came across an old man who was eating his own faeces. That sight moved him so much that he immediately took the man to a nearby hotel to buy him some idlis. "The old man ate without pausing for even a drink. If he had thanked me or blessed me that day, I would have gone on. But he simply walked away with tears in his eyes. That day, I realised my life's aim," he says.

By the following morning, much to the consternation of his parents, he had decided to walk away from his future. He set up the Akshaya Trust six months after quitting his job in 2002, steadily spending his

life's savings of Rs 1,50,000 on providing food to people of the street. "My parents were against this. So was my community," says Krishnan. But now, they are proud of him. The number of people to whom he provides food has risen. Though he started preparing food in his mother's kitchen, he later got a separate kitchen built on a road near his house.

Now, every day, a red-coloured van takes a donation from a family friend—crosses Madurai, covering a distance of 10 km daily, delivering breakfast, lunch and dinner to around 300 people. Earlier, Krishnan used to single-handedly manage the trust, but now there are three others who help him. Though he has been able to attract a few sponsors—which include local companies and individuals—the donations that he gets from them are sufficient for only 22 days in a month. "The rest of the day, I manage on my own or with the help of other donors," he says. The cost of feeding the needy runs up to Rs 8,000 per day.

Other than feeding the destitute, Krishnan has another side job. He cuts the hair of these mentally-ill people, a decision which led him to give up being a Barber. The barbers in the city had refused to take up this job. Though he has received a number of awards, all he cares for is his work. He now aims to build a foundation for the mentally ill. Though the In Foundation donated a piece of land, he has been unable to start the construction due to lack of funds. And he refuses to take help from foreign corporates as he does not want them to get tax exemptions. He will not give up though. The Akshaya van will continue to provide food to the destitute, Krishnan says. "I will never stop in this venture. I will feed them every meal if I have to."



A MOUTHFUL OF SKY: Krishnan (left) feeding a homeless man

SENTHIL KUMARAN

I will never stop in this venture. I will feed them every meal myself, if I have to.

N. KRISHNAN, Founder, Akshaya Trust

by Lakshmi Subramanian